

Banks On Technology

Technology helps Louiz Banks, the 'Godfather of Indian Jazz' create magic in the cyber-age



Louiz Banks gets cozy with his gizmos that include an HP laptop and an iMate Pocket PC

Meera Vankipuram

"I love gadgets," declares Louiz Banks, whose exploits with the electric piano have earned him the sobriquet "Godfather of Indian Jazz". Nearly 7,000 jingles, several movie scores and stage shows later, Banks continues to churn out music that appeals to young and old—thanks largely to the fact that he's one of the few musicians who have managed to keep abreast of developments in music-related technology.

"If there is any new gadget in the market, I have to buy it," he says.

In a career spanning more than a decade, Banks has composed numerous ad jingles and toured with world music band Silk. He performs regularly in stage shows, including the by-now legendary Jazz Yatra in Mumbai.

His home studio is located in a quiet niche of the otherwise bustling Santa Cruz, a western Mumbai suburb. Says Banks, "Even in a small room like this, we can create good music with hardware that costs lakhs of rupees. Because of advancements in technology... we can do wonders with the limited space. All we need is imagination and intelligence, and we can create some of the world's best music."

Gadgets abound at his workplace. There's the HP Invent laptop synchronised to the iMate Pocket PC. The iMate integrates fully with Microsoft products, and is also a tri-band GSM phone. "It has an ActiveSync with the laptop so I can transfer data back and forth," says Banks. The iMate, besides being a mobile phone, also offers him about 2 GB of storage space.

A Sony MINI DV-CAM helps Banks create

DVDs from live shows. "We use the DV-CAM to record a show, bring it to the studio, hook it up to the laptop and we can create our DVDs." His latest buy and most prized possession? The Yamaha Motif ES top-of-the-line synthesiser.

The synthesiser can be connected to his laptop, and he can record directly to the latter. The laptop can play back tunes, through the keyboard.

The laptop has become an integral part of a musician's repertoire, says Banks. "There's no need to carry six keyboards or a bank of effect processors now, to a studio. Everything is software driven. One just needs a basic keyboard, loaded with all the software and effect processing tools you would require. I can create jingles at home, on the laptop; take it to the studio, provide other inputs and record the track. This is creating a whole new breed of musicians and producers, who can now become a one-man industry."

Team Banks includes sound engineer Neil D'Souza, who is an IT (as in information technology, not income-tax) consultant and "computer wizard," according to Banks. "He looks after all my computer needs. We work as a team, creating the music. All that I create here goes into his console. He records, processes, and mixes, and helps me polish the final product."

Man Friday Neil D'Souza says, "I spend 60 per cent of my time with music. This is one field in which you get to put technology to its fullest use."

Neil uses an assembled Intel Pentium III, 870 MHz PC. He also uses a digital mixer, the Yamaha O1v, "which interfaces the analogue audio we record with the digital world."

He also uses MOTU 2408 MKII—an audio interface that connects to the computer and aids in digital sound processing. This is connected to the mixer through a fibre-optic cable. MOTU is a universal sampler plug-in that helps import, audition, and load sound banks in several formats. "Together we have a 24-channel input/output setup, eight of which are dedicated digital (input/output) channels," says Neil.

Another system called MOTU MTP AV works as the synchronisation and MIDI unit.

Louiz Banks is one artist who has managed to successfully integrate technology with creativity, to create music that appeals to the modern generation, just like southern sensation A R Rahman.

Not only does he employ technology: his extreme thirst for knowledge makes him keep track of the latest technological developments in the field of music. As Neil affirms, "He's very techno-savvy. And I'm a hardcore IT guy. That's why we vibe well." ☑

meera_vankipuram@thinkdigit.com

The DJ's Devices

- ☐ **HP Invent Laptop** – Rs 1,40,000
- ☐ **Microsoft iMate Pocket PC** – Rs 40,000
- ☐ **Sony MINI DV-CAM** – Rs 50,000
- ☐ **Yamaha Motif ES (synthesiser)** – Rs 1,25,000
- ☐ **Yamaha O1v (Digital Mixer)** – Rs 1,20,000
- ☐ **MOTU 2408 MKII** – Rs 80,000